Answering questions in class

Practical guide for students | D06-ST

Answering a question gives you an opportunity to explain and test your understanding. Focus on communicating your subject knowledge clearly, even if you need time to find the words.

1. Identify what the question asks

Listen for the main action. Are you being asked to name something, explain a cause, compare options or justify a decision?

If you are unsure, check before answering:

“Are you asking why it happened, or what happened next?”

2. Take a moment to organise your answer

Identify your main point and a reason or example. You can jot down a few key words if time allows.

If you need more time, say: “Could I have a moment to think?”

3. Start with a direct response

Give your main answer first, then develop it. Useful openings include:

- “The main reason is…”
- “One difference is…”
- “I would choose… because…”
- “The evidence suggests…”

Choose wording that fits the question.

4. Support your answer

Add a reason, example, calculation or reference to the course material. Show how it supports your point.

For a longer answer, use a simple sequence: your point, your reason and relevant evidence.

5. Clarify your meaning when needed

If you cannot recall a word, explain the idea using familiar language, an example or a diagram where appropriate.

You can also restart: “Let me explain that another way…”

Keep essential subject terms accurate and ask for help with a term if needed.

6. Use the response to improve your understanding

Listen to the teacher's feedback and other students' contributions. Check whether you need to correct your answer, add evidence or reconsider your reasoning.

If your answer was only partly correct, identify what you would change.

Example

Question "Why might a café's profit fall even when its revenue increases?"

Brief preparation Revenue up → costs increased by more → profit down

Possible answer "Profit can fall if costs increase by more than revenue. For example, the café may earn more from sales but spend even more on ingredients and staffing."

If you are uncertain "I think costs may have increased by more than revenue. Is that the relationship we should focus on?"

Check your answer

- I have answered the question asked.
- I have stated my main point clearly.
- I have added a relevant reason or example.
- I have clarified any meaning that was unclear.
- I know what to retain or change after feedback.

If answering regularly feels difficult: explain the particular difficulty to your teacher—for example, understanding the question, recalling subject knowledge or finding the English words quickly. Ask whether brief thinking time, key-word notes or pair rehearsal could help you participate.

Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). Participating in class. Open resource

Supports asking for clarification, connecting contributions to course content, building on others' ideas and treating incorrect answers as opportunities to learn. See "Asking Questions in Class", "Making Comments in Class" and "Helpful Reminders".

University of Waterloo, Centre for Teaching Excellence. (n.d.). Question strategies. Open resource

Supports allowing time to formulate answers, developing explanations with evidence and reasoning, and using clarification and elaboration to develop contributions. See "Responding to questions" and "Listening actively". Educator-facing guidance has been adapted into practical advice for students.